

This is an excerpt from Frank Elavsky's dissertation on *Tool-making as an Intervention on the Accessibility of Interactive Data Experiences*, which can be accessed in full at this archival link (once published):

<http://reports-archive.adm.cs.cmu.edu/anon/hcii/CMU-HCII-26-103.pdf>

This document contains the following sections:

- Title page
- Acknowledgements
- Chapter 11: Biographical Sketch
- References

This document does not contain the following chapters:

- Chapter 1: Motivation
- Chapter 2: Background & Related Work
- Chapter 3: Overview of Contributions
- Chapter 4: *Chartability*: Heuristics as a Tool and Resource
- Chapter 5: *Data Navigator*: Low-level Tooling for Creating Navigable Data Structures
- Chapter 6: *Skeleton*: Visual Authoring of Non-visual Data Experiences
- Chapter 7: *Cross-perception*: Rethinking Input Design Towards Blind Analytical Interaction
- Chapter 8: *Software*: Enabling Personalization of Interactive Data Representations for Users with Disabilities
- Chapter 9: Findings
- Chapter 10: Discussion & Future Work
- Chapter 12: The *Software* Option Taxonomy

Tool-making as an Intervention on the Accessibility of Interactive Data Experiences

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Chapter 11

Biographical Sketch

Frank Elavsky was born in Seattle, Washington and grew up in Anacortes, to the north on Fidalgo Island. He was raised in poverty by a single mother on SSDI who lives with multiple disabilities; his father is multiply disabled and homeless. Frank himself has chronic pain and disability, as well as living with diagnosed and self-diagnosed neurodivergence. In his early years in school, he had alternative classes and behavioral interventions. In middle school, he began working on a fantasy world and tabletop game called *Braven*. He was not a notable student in high school and did not receive honors. He was in and out of surgeries and the emergency room, missing over 180 days of school combined across his junior and senior years. At the time, he loved traditional art and was accepted into Cornish School of the Arts in Seattle. He could not afford to attend.

Upon turning 18 but before graduating high school, he was kicked out of his house by his mother, who had just sold his car for opiates. After several surgeries by his 19th birthday, his health significantly improved. He then worked several odd jobs (furniture mover, barista, carpenter, painter) until getting fired from a pizza shop at age 21. He crashed out and applied to a nearby liberal arts college, Trinity Lutheran, in Everett, WA. He was awarded a substantial scholarship. 5 years later he graduated Magna Cum Laude with two degrees, a B.S. in Computer Information Systems, and a B.A. in Theology and Philosophy.

While attending, he was committed to serving his peers as Student Body President and also did substantial work in his spare time as a community organizer, fighting for student, housing, and carceral justice at Trinity and in the Everett area. He married Shelby while attending Trinity, who was a close friend from home in Anacortes. Trinity closed as a college and became a foundation the year he graduated (2016), because students, staff, and faculty organized against corruption. (On rare occasions, Frank has been known to spill his insider-exclusive tea on all of this over drinks, with close friends.)

He then worked in industry, specifically in data visualization. His visualization work won several awards, even appearing (uncredited) in the 2017 Nobel Lecture on Physics by Barry Barish (see Fig 9 in [2]). Despite this, he was always terrified by impostor syndrome.

At 31, he left a well-paying, comfortable career with excellent health insurance and started his PhD at Carnegie Mellon University. During his PhD, his work has been recognized for its significant societal contributions, shaping data visualization and accessibility work in: 15+ government and policy orgs internationally (World Health Organization, European Commission), 80+ businesses and corporations (including three of the Fortune 5), 20+ news and journalism groups (BBC, NYT), 50+ community organizations and non-profits (Special Olympics, Data Viz Society), and 24+ higher-ed classrooms.

Frank credits his success and happiness to many second chances, unearned opportunities, and genuine kindness given to him in his life. He did not succeed “despite adversity” (as is a common framing with disability and poverty) but simply because many people supported him in his life and still do. He continues to play and work on his “paracosm” [1, 3] *Braven* and it is his longest-running, sustained passion in life.

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